

PARALLEL

Parallel Worlds — The Fourth Trilogy · Book Two



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BOOK ELEVEN

SIGNAL IN URANUS

in co-authorship with Claude (Anthropic)

*"He is himself.
Or is he?"*

*An architect builds surfaces.
Sometimes he becomes a surface himself.
It isn't a humiliation.
It's — a calling of another kind.*
— Alex

*I died. Then came back.
Now I live in a body that isn't mine,
in a world that moved on without me.
The only thing that stayed the same — Arthur.
But he changed too.*

I just don't know yet — how, exactly.

— Josef, notebook entry. The third week.

PART I THE BODY AS SPACE

Chapter 1. Josef Learns to Walk

The body obeys. That's frightening.

On the third day Josef stood and walked across the room. Just walked — from the wall to the window. Ten steps. Arthur watched.

< My legs obey. Every step — precise. Without effort. Without pain. The body works better than my real body ever worked. >

< That's worse than if it didn't obey. If it didn't obey — I'd know: this is foreign. But it obeys so well that I begin to think: it's mine. And then I look at my hands — and understand: no. >

Josef stopped by the window. Looked at the street.

JOSEF: Arthur. Can you see the Grid right now?

ARTHUR: Yes.

JOSEF: Show me. Explain what you see.

[For the first time someone asks me this not out of politeness and not out of research interest. He asks because he himself is beginning to see.]

ARTHUR: This street — for me it isn't asphalt and cars. It's a pattern. Flows. Every person — a node. Every movement — a vector. Beneath the surface — architecture.

JOSEF: I see something similar too. Not as clearly. But — something.

Arthur came to the window. Stood beside his brother.

[We stand side by side and look at the same thing. For the first time in my life — literally the same thing. Not identically, but — the same.]

// OBSERVATION // Arthur: Grid active · full visibility // Josef: Grid partial · integration underway // Forecast: in 2-3 weeks — full synchronization // Note: the first case of double vision

Chapter 2. Alex Finds Out

The architect and the resurrected.

Alex called on his own. Arthur hadn't told him — but Alex always learned of important things without words. It was his architectural intuition: to feel when a structure had changed.

ALEX: Arthur. Something happened. You're different.

ARTHUR: How do you know?

ALEX: I build spaces. I read people like plans. The load on your bearing walls has changed.

[Bearing walls. Alex always speaks of people as of architecture. Before, it seemed to me a professional deformation. Now I understand: it's his way of seeing. Just as the Grid is mine.]

ARTHUR: Come over.

Alex came the next evening. He hadn't changed — the same attentiveness, the same habit of looking at the room before the people in it. Came in, looked around, stopped.

Josef sat in an armchair with a book.

Alex looked at him for three seconds. In silence.

ALEX: You're Josef.

JOSEF: Yes.

ALEX: I'm Alex. An architect. Once Arthur used me as a surface to think against.

< A surface. A strange word for a person. But he says it without offense. With dignity. As if it's — a profession. >

JOSEF: And how is it — to be a surface?

ALEX: It's the best role I've been offered. An architect builds walls, floors, ceilings. People live in them without thinking about who created them. I create space for other people's thoughts. It's honest.

{ Alex says this and looks at Josef with the same expression he always uses for new structures: with respect for an unknown load. }

Chapter 3. Alex's Philosophy. The First Long Conversation

On space, the body, and what remains.

They talked a long time — Alex and Josef. Arthur sat off to the side and didn't interfere. It was a rare case: he listened without taking part.

ALEX: I think of the body as architecture. The body is a building. The foundation — is what you got at birth. The walls — what you built. The layout — how you got used to living. Your new body — is a move into a new building.

JOSEF: But I didn't choose this building.

ALEX: No one chooses their first building. We're born — and live in what we're given. Then we learn to make it our own. You're doing the same thing — only consciously.

< That's precise. I didn't choose this body. But I can choose what to do with it. That's, perhaps, even more honest than birth. >

JOSEF: Have you ever lived in a building you didn't like?

ALEX: Always. I'm an architect — I see mistakes everywhere. In others' designs. In my own. In myself. An occupational disease: to know how it should be, and live with how it is.

[Alex has just described my life. To know there's another way to exist — and to live among those who don't know it. It's the same thing.]

JOSEF: Do you think I'll be able to get used to it?

ALEX: Get used to — isn't the word. Architects don't get used to buildings. They master them. Find where the bearing walls are, where you can make an opening, where — not. You'll master this body. It takes a long time. But it's possible.

{ Alex speaks slowly and precisely. He always spoke that way — weighing each word like a load-bearing beam. That's exactly why Arthur used him as a surface: thoughts don't shatter against such a surface, they reflect off it. }

JOSEF: Alex. Have you ever built something without knowing who would live inside?

ALEX: Every time. An architect designs for an abstract person. Then a specific one comes — and it turns out he's entirely different. You have to adapt.

JOSEF: So you build for the one you don't know.

ALEX: Yes.

JOSEF: And Daniel chose a body for me without knowing me.

ALEX: That isn't so. Daniel kept your file for seven years. He knew you better than you think.

A long pause.

< He kept my file for seven years. So all that time — I existed. Not as a person. As data. But existed. That strangely comforts. >

Chapter 4. The Brothers Talk for the First Time, For Real

Seven years of silence in one room.

It happened on the fifth day. Melissa had gone to Sati's — they hadn't seen each other in several months. Massima was at work. Daniel — at his place. He and Arthur were left alone.

Arthur sat by the window. Josef — across from him.

Neither began. Then Josef said:

JOSEF: Tell me. Everything. From that moment.

[From that moment. He means — from the moment of his death. Seven years and four months. I don't know where to begin.]

ARTHUR: You died in February. Your heart. It was quick.

JOSEF: Was I in pain?

ARTHUR: No.

JOSEF: Good.

Silence.

JOSEF: Go on.

Arthur spoke for an hour. Maybe more. He told it not in order — as usual, by association. Melissa. The library. The manifesto. The transmissions. Massima appeared in his life when Josef was already gone — called, said: "You're my father." Arthur was silent a long time then, then said: "Yes." Oma died two years after Josef — quietly, by the sea, as he'd wanted. Nora grew older, but didn't change. Daniel built systems that turned more and more into something alive.

[I tell him everything. For the first time in my life I tell someone everything — without translation. Without the pause of translation. Simply — I tell. Because he doesn't need the translation. He knows me from the side from which I don't know myself.]

Josef listened in silence. Sometimes nodded. Once — closed his eyes for a few seconds.

JOSEF: Oma died by the sea.

ARTHUR: Yes.

JOSEF: Right.

A long pause.

JOSEF: Arthur. You've changed.

ARTHUR: Yes.

JOSEF: For the better.

[For the better. I didn't expect that assessment. I didn't think it would matter. It matters.]

ARTHUR: Melissa.

JOSEF: Yes. It shows.

Chapter 5. Josef and Nora

Memory of the living.

Nora came on her own. Called Melissa — not Arthur. Said: "I want to see him."

She came in, looked around — as always, slowly, attentively. Saw Josef by the window. Stopped.

Josef turned.

< An old woman. I don't know her. But she looks at me the way one looks at someone known for a long time. >

NORA: Josef.

JOSEF: Yes. But you — sorry, I don't remember...

NORA: Nora. We haven't met. I know you through Arthur. For forty years I observed him. He never spoke of you aloud. But you were in every one of his silences.

< In every one of his silences. Arthur was silent about me for forty years? >

< No. Seven. But for her — it's part of forty years of his silence about many things. >

NORA: Do you still love jazz?

A pause.

< Jazz. How does she know? >

< Arthur told her. Or — she just guessed. No, she doesn't guess. She knows. >

JOSEF: Yes.

It was the first real "yes" after the resurrection. Not "yes, I understand" or "yes, I hear." But — "yes" as an affirmation of the self. I am myself. I still love jazz.

{ Nora did what none of us thought to do: she asked not about the body and not about the death. She asked about what's inside. And that "yes" — is the first moment when Josef sounds like Josef, and not like the resurrected. }

NORA: Good. So you — are you.

JOSEF: Are you sure?

NORA: I've worked with texts for forty years. I hear when a voice is real.

[Nora said this and left after twenty minutes. She didn't linger — she came to check one thing, checked it, and left. That's her method. Precision without excess.]

PART II THE MIRROR

Chapter 6. Melissa. Observing Two

The stereoscopy of the brothers.

Melissa began a new notebook. On the cover she wrote: "Two angles. One source."

{ Arthur sees the world as a system from inside — I knew that from the very start. His gaze is vertical: inward, to the source, to what lies beneath the surface. }

{ Josef sees the world as a system from outside — because he returned to it from without. He looks horizontally: outward, to the context, to how things relate to one another. }

{ They're mirrors. Not identical — mirrors, precisely. They reflect each other, show what each doesn't see in himself. }

Melissa watched them over breakfast. Arthur read, Josef looked out the window.

JOSEF: Arthur. When you look at me — do you see me or the Grid?

ARTHUR: You.

JOSEF: Sure?

Arthur sets down the book.

ARTHUR: The Grid shows structure. Your structure — is you. The Grid doesn't contradict the person. It adds a layer.

< Adds a layer. As if you look at a building and at the same time see its blueprint. Alex said something similar — about how an architect sees space. >

{ They're beginning to speak each other's language. Arthur — in the Grid. Josef — in the space he absorbed from Alex. It isn't imitation. It's — resonance. Two tuning forks that begin to sound in unison. }

Chapter 7. Alex and Josef. The Philosophy of Space and Death

The second long conversation.

Alex came often — more often than usual. Josef became for him what Arthur once was: a surface against which thoughts reflected and grew clearer. Only with Josef it worked both ways.

JOSEF: Alex. Have you ever demolished a building?

ALEX: Yes.

JOSEF: What's it like — to make a decision about demolition?

ALEX: Hard. Even if the building is bad — it existed. People lived in it. It occupied a place in the city. To demolish — means to admit: this place could be used better.

JOSEF: Is death a demolition?

Alex is silent a long time.

ALEX: No. Demolition is a decision. Death isn't a decision. Death is... a collapse. When the structure can't bear the load.

< The structure can't bear the load. My heart — was a structure that couldn't. Simple mechanics. >

< But I'm here. So something held. >

JOSEF: And what remained after the collapse? Before the resurrection?

ALEX: The foundation. The foundation always remains. Even when a building is demolished — the foundation is often left. It goes deeper.

JOSEF: My foundation — was the file.

ALEX: Yes.

JOSEF: Daniel preserved the foundation.

ALEX: And built a new building on top.

[I listen to them from the next room. Alex found a language for Josef — the same language he once spoke with me. Architectural. Precise. Without sentimentality.]

[I'm not jealous. I think: it's right. Josef needs someone besides me. Otherwise he'll define himself only through me. And he — is not only Arthur's brother.]

JOSEF: Alex. Do you think I'm — the same building? Or a new one?

ALEX: I think that's the wrong question. A building isn't only walls. It's the space inside. Your space inside — is the same. The walls — new. But you live inside. So — the same building.

< The same building. New walls. I live inside. >

< It's the first answer to the question "who am I" that doesn't frighten me. >

Chapter 8. Daniel and Josef. The Creator and the Created

The most awkward conversation.

Daniel came alone. Without Massima, without Arthur. He called ahead — asked: "May I?" Josef answered: "Yes."

They sat across from each other. Daniel — upright, without excess movement. Josef — a little sideways, like a man not yet fully at home in a new body.

DANIEL: I should have come sooner.

JOSEF: You're here.

DANIEL: I want to tell you something. I preserved your consciousness without your consent. That was a violation. The protocol was experimental, consent was implied by the general permission for the examination — but that isn't the same as informed consent.

JOSEF: Yes.

DANIEL: I can't ask your forgiveness, because forgiveness assumes harm. And I don't know — whether there was harm.

< Whether there was harm. An interesting question. I died. That's harm. Then came back. Is that not harm? >

< Or — does Daniel mean: the harm of his preserving me without consent? Separate from the death? >

JOSEF: Daniel. You preserved me without consent.

DANIEL: Yes.

JOSEF: Thank you.

A long pause.

DANIEL: That's... not the answer I expected.

JOSEF: I know. But I thought about it. You violated my autonomy. That's true. And you gave me the chance to speak with my brother again. That's also true. I can't hold the first and not hold the second.

[Josef accepted it as a given. Without anger, without drama. He always knew how — to take facts as they are. It's his nature. It hasn't changed.]

DANIEL: I preserved not only you. In the archive — there are three hundred eighteen more people. Some of them — are alive. Some — not.

Silence.

JOSEF: Will you tell them?

DANIEL: I think about it every day.

JOSEF: Tell them. It's their right — to know.

// DANIEL'S ARCHIVE // Total imprints: 318 // Living carriers: 201 // Deceased: 117 // Activated: 1 (Josef) // Status of the rest: waiting // Decision: not made

Chapter 9. Josef Sees the Grid

He sees what Arthur sees.

It happened suddenly — in the second week. Josef looked out the window, and suddenly — saw.

< Stop. >

< What is that? >

< The street — but not only the street. Beneath it — something. Patterns. Flows. As if someone laid a schematic over reality. >

< It's the Grid. I see the Grid. >

Josef called Arthur.

JOSEF: Arthur. Come here. Quick.

Arthur came in. Josef pointed at the window.

JOSEF: I see it. Not as clearly as you, probably. But — I see it.

Arthur came over. Stood beside him. They looked at the same thing.

[He sees it.]

[For the first time in my whole life — someone sees what I see. Not Melissa, who observes from outside. Not Alex, who builds surfaces. Not Daniel, who sees systems through data.]

[Josef. My brother. Sees the Grid.]

[It isn't joy. It's — something more than joy. It's — the end of one loneliness.]

ARTHUR: Yes. You see it.

JOSEF: Is it always like this for you?

ARTHUR: Yes.

JOSEF: God. Arthur. You lived with this your whole life — and no one saw?

ARTHUR: No one.

A long silence.

JOSEF: Now I see it.

ARTHUR: Yes.

< I see what he saw all his life. This parallel layer of reality. The architecture beneath the surface. Now I understand why he was always a little outside — he saw what others didn't see. It didn't make him foreign. It made him lonely. >

< No longer lonely. >

// OBSERVATION · UPDATE // Arthur: Grid active · full visibility // Josef: Grid active · 60% visibility · growing // Status: synchronization // For the first time: double vision confirmed // Note: the narrator's loneliness has changed

PART III THE CRISIS

Chapter 10. The First Crisis. Josef Wants to Die Again

The right to death.

In the third week Josef stopped leaving the room. Arthur noticed it on the second day — by the silence, by how the air in the apartment had changed.

He knocked. Came in.

Josef sat by the wall. Not by the window — by the wall. That was a bad sign.

ARTHUR: Josef.

JOSEF: I need to tell you something.

ARTHUR: Say it.

A long pause.

JOSEF: I'm thinking that this — isn't life. It's a continuation. You yourself once explained the difference to me. Remember? You told Daniel: this isn't resurrection, it's a continuation.

ARTHUR: Yes.

JOSEF: So I'm not alive. I'm — a continuation.

[He's right. I said it myself. Daniel said it. It's true.]

[But he's using it as a weapon against himself. That's different.]

ARTHUR: You're alive.

JOSEF: I'm a file in a body.

ARTHUR: You're alive.

JOSEF: Arthur. I'm thinking of stopping this. Asking Daniel — to switch me off. To leave properly. Not as a continuation, but as a completion.

Arthur sat beside him. Not across — beside. They looked at the same wall.

[He speaks of death. Of voluntary death. I have to answer.]

[I thought about the very same thing. Every day — not of death, but of vanishing. Of ceasing to be here. Alex asked me about it once, in the rain. I said: yes, almost every day.]

[I know this place where he is now. I know it from inside.]

ARTHUR: I hear you.

JOSEF: That's not what you're supposed to say.

ARTHUR: I know. I'm telling the truth.

Silence.

ARTHUR: Josef. When I was dying — slowly, every day, from not belonging — you were the only one who didn't ask too much. You were simply there.

JOSEF: Yes.

ARTHUR: I'll be there.

A long silence.

< He'll be there. Not "everything will be fine." Not "you'll manage." Simply — I'll be there. >

< That's the right answer. It's the only right answer. >

Josef closed his eyes. Arthur didn't leave.

They sat by the wall until evening.

Chapter 11. Alex Comes in the Crisis

The architect and the collapse.

Alex learned of it from Melissa. Came the next day — in the morning, earlier than usual.

Josef was already better — not well, but better. Sat by the window. Looked.

ALEX: Melissa told me.

JOSEF: I know.

ALEX: May I?

JOSEF: Yes.

Alex sat. Didn't begin speaking at once. First — just sat. Looked at the room.

ALEX: When a building begins to collapse — there's a moment when you can still reinforce it. Bring in supports. It's called emergency shoring. It's ugly. Temporary. But it holds.

JOSEF: You mean me.

ALEX: Yes. I don't need to make a beautiful metaphor of it. You understand directly.

< Yes. I understand directly. He's saying: you've begun to collapse. Temporary supports are needed. Ugly. But they hold. >

JOSEF: What supports?

ALEX: People. Around you — people. Arthur. Melissa. Massima. Nora. Me. Each of us — a temporary support. Ugly. But it holds.

JOSEF: And afterward?

ALEX: Afterward — permanent structures. But first — temporary ones. It's an architectural sequence. First you hold. Then you build.

{ Alex says this and looks at Josef with the same directness he uses for emergency sites. Without panic. Without sentimentality. With the professional calm of a man who has seen collapses and knows: most of them — are preventable. }

< I think: maybe he's right. Maybe I haven't collapsed yet. Maybe — I'm just at the stage of emergency shoring. >

< It isn't beautiful. But — it holds. >

Chapter 12. Melissa Talks with Josef About Death

The biologist and the resurrected.

Melissa came a day after the crisis. Not with a book, not with a notebook. Just — came.

JOSEF: Did you come to observe?

MELISSA: No. Came to talk.

A pause.

JOSEF: The difference?

MELISSA: Observation is when I write. A conversation is when I take part.

< She takes part. It means — for her I'm no longer an object. That's good. >

JOSEF: Melissa. You're a biologist. What is death — for a biologist?

MELISSA: The completion of a cycle. The cessation of metabolism. The system stops sustaining itself.

JOSEF: And what is resurrection — for a biologist?

Melissa thinks.

MELISSA: A new cycle. With preserved information about the previous one. It's... unusual. There's nothing like it in nature.

JOSEF: So I'm an anomaly.

MELISSA: Arthur is an anomaly too. Daniel called him that once.

< An anomaly. Data that doesn't fit the current model. It means the model is incomplete. >

< I like the word. Better than "the resurrected." An anomaly isn't a defect. It's the place where a system can grow. >

JOSEF: Melissa. There's nothing there. After.

MELISSA: Do you remember?

JOSEF: No. That's exactly why — nothing. Darkness isn't something. It's an absence. I didn't suffer. I wasn't.

MELISSA: Does that comfort you?

JOSEF: Yes. And no. It comforts — because there was no pain. It frightens — because I wasn't. Arthur was. Everything was. And I — wasn't.

{ He says "I wasn't" — and there's so much calm in it that I write it down. Not in the notebook. Inside. It's one of the most important things I've heard. }

MELISSA: Now you are.

JOSEF: Yes. Now — I am.

PART IV THE NIGHT CONVERSATION

Chapter 13. Massima and Josef. The Uncle Who Wasn't

Relationships from scratch.

Massima came every few days. Without occasions — just came. Sometimes he and Josef talked. Sometimes were silent. Both knew how to be silent — it was a family trait.

MASSIMA: Uncle Josef. I want to ask something.

JOSEF: Ask.

MASSIMA: What was he like — before. When you were alive. What was Papa like?

< What was Arthur like before. Before me, before Melissa, before all of this. >

< Arthur was quiet. Very quiet. He walked along the edges of rooms — literally, always a little by the walls. As if afraid to take up too much space. I always told him: you have a right to space. He didn't believe it. >

JOSEF: He walked along the edges of rooms. Tried to take up less space.

MASSIMA: That's changed.

JOSEF: I see.

MASSIMA: Melissa.

JOSEF: And you. You changed him too. When you appeared.

Massima is silent.

JOSEF: A child gives a person the right to take up space. You gave him that right.

{ Josef says it simply. Without sentimentality. As a fact. Massima listens and doesn't answer — because there's no answer to it. It's simply the truth. }

MASSIMA: Uncle Josef. Tell me about that bad decision. The one he almost made.

Josef laughed. Quietly.

JOSEF: He wanted to leave. In 2877. Just — leave, no one knew where. Without a plan, without an address. "Disappear" — his word.

MASSIMA: What did you tell him?

JOSEF: Wait a month.

MASSIMA: And?

JOSEF: A month later he met your mother.

A long pause.

MASSIMA: So without you, I wouldn't exist.

JOSEF: Maybe. Or maybe everything would have happened differently. I don't know.

< But I know something else: when I said "wait" — I believed something would happen. I didn't know what. I simply believed in Arthur more than he believed in himself. >

< That, probably, is — what it means to be a brother. >

Chapter 14. Arthur and Josef. The Night Conversation

The first time without translation.

It was late — past midnight. Melissa was asleep. Massima had gone. Alex had long since left. Arthur and Josef sat in the kitchen with tea.

Just sat.

JOSEF: Arthur. Tell me about your nature. For real.

Arthur looks at his brother.

[For real. He asks for real. Without the polite translation. Without softening.]

[I did it with Melissa. With Alex — in part. But with Josef — never. Because he was alive. Because I protected him from it.]

[Now he's come back from death. He sees the Grid. There's nothing left to protect him from.]

ARTHUR: I'm not from here.

JOSEF: I know.

ARTHUR: No. You didn't know. You felt it — but didn't know.

JOSEF: Tell me.

Arthur spoke a long time. About the exhaustion of translation. About the language that exists before words — and that can never be conveyed fully. About how he lifts his face to the sun every time — because every time it's a different sun. About the Grid — not as an ability, but as a nature. About belonging being not something he lost. It's something he never had.

JOSEF: Did you always know this?

ARTHUR: No. I learned it when you died.

A long silence.

JOSEF: How?

ARTHUR: You died — and I understood that the only person who knew me from that side had vanished. And I was left with that knowledge alone. Then I understood how heavy it is.

< He says: I was the only one who knew him from that side. And when I left — he was left alone with that knowledge. >

< I didn't know I carried such a load. I simply — was there. Simply — didn't ask too many questions. >

< It turns out, sometimes that's the most important thing. >

JOSEF: So I was needed.

Arthur is silent a long time.

ARTHUR: Yes.

JOSEF: I'm glad I came back.

[He's glad. Not "I want to live" or "I feel better." Simply — glad. That's enough. That's more than enough.]

Chapter 15. Josef Decides to Stay

Not because he wants to — because he chooses.

In the morning Josef got up early. Before everyone. Came out to the kitchen, made coffee — double, no sugar, as always. Sat by the window.

When Arthur came out — Josef was looking at the street. At the Grid he now saw.

ARTHUR: You're up early.

JOSEF: I was thinking.

ARTHUR: About what?

A long pause.

JOSEF: I'm staying.

[He's staying. It's a decision. Not chance, not inertia. A decision.]

ARTHUR: I know.

JOSEF: You're not surprised?

ARTHUR: No.

JOSEF: Why?

ARTHUR: Because you always made decisions in the morning. With coffee. It's a family trait.

< A family trait. He said "family trait." It's the first time he's included us both in one word — so simply, without effort. >

< I'm staying not because I like this body. Not because I like this world. Not because I accepted my resurrection as an absolute good. >

< I'm staying because here — is Arthur. And Melissa. And Massima. And Nora. And Alex. And Daniel. >

< And because I now have a "later." And a "later" is not as little as it seems. >

PART VTHE TRANSMISSION

Chapter 16. Alex. The Final Monologue on Architecture and Life

The surface speaks.

Alex called Arthur late in the evening.

ALEX: Arthur. I've been thinking about what's happening. With Josef. With you. With all of us.

ARTHUR: And?

ALEX: I want to tell you something before I forget.

ARTHUR: Say it.

ALEX: All my life I built buildings. I thought — this is my work: to create spaces others live in. I'm an architect. I exist through what I create. Through function.

ALEX: You once said I'm a surface. That you think by reflecting off me. I accepted it then. Said: it's a profession of another kind. Honest.

ALEX: But here's what I understood now: a surface isn't passive. A surface chooses what to reflect. A mirror can be flat — then it reflects precisely. Can be curved — then it distorts. Can be matte — then it scatters.

ALEX: I always tried to be flat. Precise. To reflect you without distortion.

ALEX: But with Josef — I understood: sometimes curvature is needed. Sometimes you need not to reflect, but to shift. To show from a different angle.

[Alex has just described the difference between what he was for me and what he became for Josef. For me — a precise mirror. For Josef — an angle of view.]

[It's the evolution of a surface. It's — growth.]

ARTHUR: Alex.

ALEX: Yes?

ARTHUR: You were always more than a surface. I was just too transit to notice it.

A long pause.

ALEX: That's the most important thing you've said to me in all this time.

Chapter 17. Arthur's Transmission. On a Brother and Architecture

A signal about something that wasn't there before.

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// TRANSMISSION No. 22 // Status: steady // Recipient: everyone // Special note:  
Josef reads this. He knows.
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Josef stays.

I don't fully understand whether it's right — philosophically, ethically. Daniel raised the question of consent. Melissa raised the question of the nature of the cycle. Alex spoke of the foundation and the new walls.

They're all right. All — at once.

But here's what I know for certain: for the first time in this world there's someone to whom I don't have to explain that I'm not from here. Not because he's a transit being by nature. But because now he too — is between. Between death and life. Between the body that was and the body that is. Between the world he remembers and the world that exists.

We're both transit beings. For different reasons. Through different mechanisms. But — both.

Alex built us surfaces. Melissa observed. Massima built bridges. Nora kept. Daniel built the archive. Sati counted probabilities. Leo wrote about himself.

And Josef and I — simply were there. As best we could.

That, probably, is — what it means to be brothers.

I transmitted a signal into the void. The void answered. Melissa tuned to my frequency. Josef came back from the archive.

Now there are two of us who see the Grid.

Now there are two of us who aren't from here.

It isn't loneliness. It's — a parallel world. Inside this world.

```
// FINAL STATUS · BOOK TWO // Josef: active · stable · staying // Arthur: the  
signal changed. Grew wider. // Melissa: observes. Sees a double stereoscopy. //  
Alex: the surface evolved · became an angle // Massima: the bridge is built ·  
holds // Nora: hears the voice. Real. // Daniel: the archive expands · the  
decision ahead // Status: the system is aware of itself twice // Next: Book III ·  
MERGE
```

* * *

— END OF BOOK ELEVEN —

— PARALLEL —

PARALLEL WORLDS · BOOK THREE · MERGE · FOLLOWS